HIRING · 12 WEEKS · 1/10

Hire for failure handling, not framework enthusiasm.

The 12-week arc I use to hire engineers who survive a broken production — not just pass a whiteboard.

10 slides · swipe

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Enthusiasm expires the moment it breaks.

Anyone can demo a happy path. The people you actually need are the ones who debug a half-dead pipeline at 2 a.m. and leave it better than they found it.

Enthusiasm is free.
Failure judgment is rare.

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HIRING · WEEK 1 · 3/10

Week 1: map the wreckage.

01 Give them the production incident log — all of it

02 Ask: what would you fix first, and why that one?

03 Watch how they read before how they type

If they start coding before mapping, they're decorators, not engineers.

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Weeks 2–4: own one recurring failure.

01 One recurring incident, theirs to chase end-to-end

02 Fix it — or prove why it can't be fixed yet

03 Every artifact recorded: logs, chat, decision

Watch for blameless language — that's the senior signal.

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HIRING · WEEKS 5-8 · 5/10

Weeks 5–8: one operational boundary.

01 One service, one boundary — fully theirs

02 They write the runbook, on-call, alerts

03 You measure: deploy frequency, MTTR, honesty

Boundaries expose ownership — repos of 10 are just commit counts.

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Weeks 9–12: the verdict.

01 Did the recurring incident disappear or shrink?

↓

02 Did they document what they broke — and how they recovered?

↓

03 Would your 3 a.m. self trust their runbook?

Their answer teaches you everything — the CV tells you nothing.

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Red flags this arc exposes fast.

01 Rewrites instead of fixes — always a new stack

02 Fixes without verification — hope-based engineering

03 Blaming infra, teammates, users — never the boundary

04 No artifacts — 'I fixed it' with no evidence trail

One pattern is a skill gap. Two is a character trait.

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Two interview outcomes.

PERFORMS	VERIFIES
Framework resume	**Failure judgment**
knows the syntax impresses the panel vanishes at 3 a.m.	traces the chain names the cause stays for the fix

One hires a resume. The other hires a partner.

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If you're reading this while hiring.

Twelve weeks costs less than one bad senior hire's first quarter. Run the arc. Trust the artifacts. Your future on-call will know the difference.

**Interview for the incident,
not the job description.**

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HIRING · THE ASK · 10/10

Looking for a Python/AI backend role?

If your team hires for failure handling and values honest artifacts — I'm open. antonpetnitsky.com

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